Supplementary

The Friendship

On a clear day in December 26, 2004, in the African country of Kenya a group of hippopotamuses (hippos) were swimming by the ocean. At that time, the Indian Ocean tsunami struck the Kenyan coast. The hippos were carried away into the sea by the tall, strong waves.

The next day the people came to the beach to look at the damage. They couldn't see the group of hippos. But they did see the baby hippo on some rocks.

A number of people came down the beach to rescue the baby hippo. But it was not easy. Firstly, the baby was 600 pounds or about 270 Kg. No one could carry him like a baby. He was tired and frightened and hungry. So, he kept running away and rushing at the people. He was fast and slippery and was not easy to catch.



They used ropes, nets, boats and cars. But they were able to catch him only after a man called Owen wrestled the baby hippo to the ground. So, they called the baby Owen.

Owen was taken to a wild life sanctuary. Everyone thought he could be well looked after there. But Owen was not happy at all. He was tired and very frightened. As soon as he reached the sanctuary, he saw a large greyish tortoise. It looked a bit like his mother. He ran to the creature and hid behind it. Just like a baby hippo would hide behind its mother. The animal he chose was a 130-year-old giant tortoise called Mzee. Mzee was very surprised by Owen. But he let Owen cuddle close to him. Soon the two of them became friends.

At first, Owen did not know what to eat and how to eat. But he followed Mzee and started copying him just as he would have done with his mother. And Mzee taught Owen to eat the leaves, grasses and things that he ate. The two became good friends and would walk around together, swim together, sleep together and eat together. Soon they learnt to tell each other what they wanted to do.

This friendship astonished the people in the wild life park. It was unusual for a mammal and a reptile to bond and become friends. But that is what happened. Owen lost his mother and adopted a giant tortoise and learned to survive. The two of them became quite famous as a lot of news channels wrote and spoke about them. Even today you will find a lot of videos which show you the story of Owen and Mzee on the Internet.

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